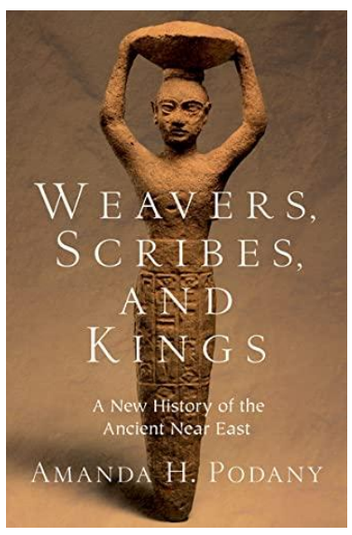


kindle

Weavers, Scribes, and Kings: A New History of the Ancient Near East

by Amanda H. Podany

Free Kindle instant preview: https://read.amazon.com/kp/kshare?asin=B0B8P5S3CV

Annotations (175)

- 114 Highlights | Yellow (114)
- 3 Bookmarks | Blue (3)
- 58 Notes

Introduction

Page 4 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Uruk, in southern Iraq, around 3500 bce. Uruk was the first true city anywhere in the ancient Near East, and probably the largest city on Earth at the time. It was also where the region’s wedge-shaped cuneiform writing was invented,

Aug 15, 2026

Note:

For timeline of largest cities

Aug 15, 2026

Page 13 | Highlight (Yellow)

> By this time, humans had been living on the planet for millions of years, modern humans (Homo sapiens sapiens) for around 200,000 years. They had been speaking fully developed languages for at least tens of thousands of years.

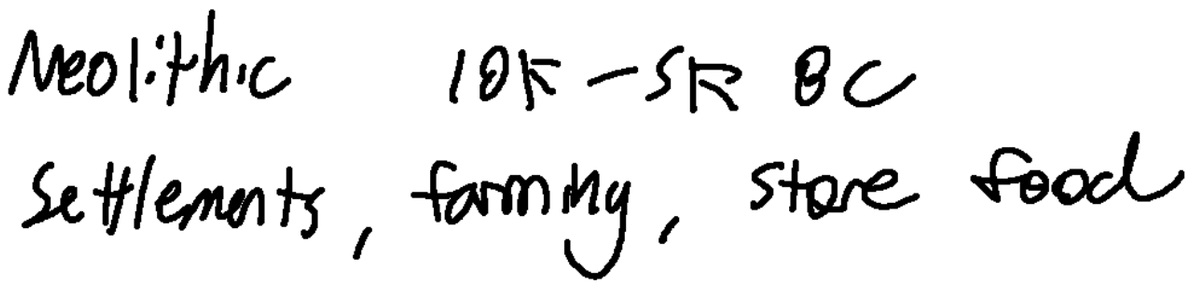
Aug 15, 2026

Page 14 | Highlight (Yellow)

> This period is called the Neolithic, and in the Near East it lasted from around 10000 bce to around 5300

Aug 15, 2026

Note:



Aug 15, 2026

Page 16 | Highlight (Yellow)

> At that time, perhaps as many as 40,000 of the newly urbanized people lived in Uruk. A gathering of that many people today at a football stadium would be unremarkable, and a town of 40,000 is not a big place in the modern world. But for the fourth millennium bce, it was astounding. The world had never seen anything like it. In fact, a city that big continued to be a rarity for millennia. Uruk was 2.5 square kilometers (a square mile) in extent, and was on a completely different scale from its neighbors: ten times the size, in fact, of the next biggest city in the region.6 Uruk was already the same size as Athens in 500 bce, 3,000 years later.7

Aug 15, 2026

Page 18 | Highlight (Yellow)

> complex was called the Eanna, the “house of the heavens.” Within the Eanna stood a truly remarkable

> building. We often describe things offhandedly as “unique” while knowing that it’s not really true, but this building was exactly that. Nothing remotely like it has ever been found. It was constructed during what the excavators called Level VI, around perhaps 3500

Aug 16, 2026

Note:



Aug 16, 2026

Page 34 | Bookmark (Blue)



Aug 17, 2026

2. Colonizers, Scribes, and the Gods

Page 41 | Highlight (Yellow)

> At the beginning of Level IV at Uruk, many new monumental buildings were constructed in the sacred precinct of the Eanna in the heart of the city.12 By now, the complex was immense; it covered about 9 hectares (22 acres).13 To give you a sense of scale, that is an area about three times larger than the much later acropolis in Athens.

Aug 18, 2026

Note:

Try to make Timeline w/ levels of
detail

Aug 18, 2026

Page 44 | Highlight (Yellow)

> On the earliest proto-cuneiform tablets, the administrators included numerical signs impressed with a stylus, in various shapes, with no indication of what was being counted. After a while, they began to divide up the surface of the clay tablet with incised lines, and to add pictograms to identify commodities (see Fig. 2.1). Each box on the front of the tablet—the obverse—usually contained a number and a picture.

Aug 18, 2026

Note:

3200 BCE

Aug 18, 2026

Page 49 | Highlight (Yellow)

> We know from images on early cylinder seals that a favorite social event involved arranging chairs around a big pot of beer, gathering friends or family members together, and drinking it through long straws (see Fig. 2.2). Kushim might well have done this himself,

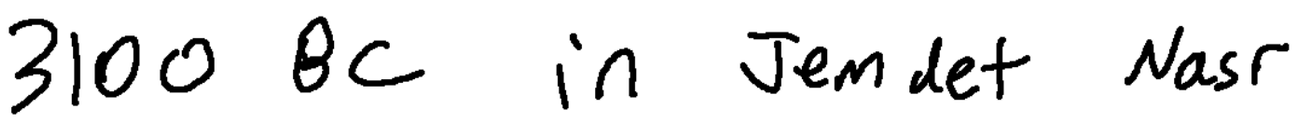
Aug 18, 2026

Page 52 | Highlight (Yellow)

> It’s a list of fields, and for each field, the scribe provided its dimensions—the length, the width, the perimeter or the area of the field—along with the profession of the person who controlled it. They were all important officials. At the end, of course, is a total of all the land listed. The first five fields listed were rectangular, of about the same large size, and three times as long as they were wide. Throughout Mesopotamian history, fields were generally long and narrow.51 The landscape seems to have been divided up pretty regularly, even at this remarkably early date. A centralized authority hides behind this fact;

Aug 18, 2026

Note:



Aug 18, 2026

Page 54 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Although houses haven’t been excavated at Uruk itself, we know from other Mesopotamian cities of the same period that their houses had rooms, furniture, doors, and windows (though without glass, which had not yet been invented). They cooked their meals in ovens and ate from pottery bowls. Their diet was based on bread, fish, vegetables (they loved onions and garlic), fruits, and some meat (beef, pork, lamb, goat). They drank beer. They wore clothes made of wool and linen.

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

Why no houses excavated in vault?

Aug 19, 2026

Page 54 | Highlight (Yellow)

> I suspect that it will change a great deal more in future and that “ancient history” will come to be seen as everything up to about the beginning of the eighteenth century ce when technology began to leap forward.

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

shifting boundaries of history

Aug 19, 2026

Page 57 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Inana in the Eanna temple (see Fig. 2.3). Excavators found a life-size marble face during the excavations there that is surely too carefully made to be anything but a representation of the goddess herself.55 It now resides in the National Museum of Iraq in Baghdad: a strikingly naturalistic marble representation of a woman whose eyes, eyebrows, and hair would have been inlaid with gold and semi-precious stones (though these inlays are lost). Her body would have been made of wood or precious metals.

Aug 19, 2026

3. Kings and Subjects

Page 64 | Highlight (Yellow)

> By now, the signs no longer looked anything like pictures; the script from this era onward is called “cuneiform.” In the Early Dynastic period, a few people began to use cuneiform to write about themselves—not often, and not in much depth—but we get clearer glimpses of them in the cuneiform texts.

Aug 19, 2026

Note: cuneiform 2900 bc

Aug 19, 2026

Page 68 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The city of Umma was watched over by the god Shara, whose temple was one of the most impressive in all of Sumer.12 The ruler of Umma controlled not just the city itself but several smaller cities and towns,13 along with the villages and lands around the city—it was a city-state. Sumer was dotted with city-states, each home to at least one city god or goddess and each with its own government. (The same was true of the region of Akkad, which lay to the north of Sumer.) Directly to the east of Umma was its neighbor, the city-state of Lagash, with which it is always associated, as though they were ancient twins (though very argumentative twins).

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

3 Mesopotamian city-states: (map them)

1) Sumer (city: Umer)
2) Akkad
3) Lagash

+ R.3h in Iraq

2900-2300 BC - Early Dynastic period / Kings

Aug 19, 2026

Page 71 | Highlight (Yellow)

> There is one other achievement that he thought to include, this one next to the second image of the king: he "had ships of Dilmun submit timber as tribute from foreign lands (to Lagash)."22 Dilmun was hundreds of kilometers to the south of Lagash on the shores of the Persian Gulf, in what is now Bahrain. It seems improbable that Lagash controlled Dilmun, so the "tribute" may have been something more in the nature of trade, but evidence from Bahrain confirms that it was serving as a trading center for the whole

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

King Ur-Nanshe of Lagash takes trade from Dilmun in Bahrain

Aug 19, 2026

Page 72 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Ur-Nanshe rarely mentioned war or conflict—only twice, in fact. In his longest inscription he wrote that he “went to war against the leader of Ur and the leader of Gesha” and that he “defeated and [captured] the leader of Ur” and “defeated the leader of Gesha.”25 Gesha was used as another name for Umma, the city-state that neighbored Lagash. This was the start of the long hostilities between the two kingdoms. He fought farther away, as well, in Elam, to the east of Lagash in what is now western Iran.

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

Map all of these 4 city states on prev note

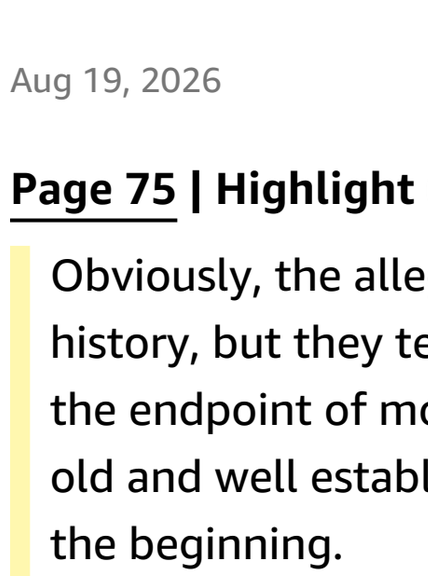
Aug 19, 2026

Page 75 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Obviously, the alleged reigns in the Sumerian King List were absurdly long and lay in the realm of legend, not history, but they tell us that the people of Early Dynastic Sumer probably believed themselves to be living at the endpoint of more than 400,000 years of civilization. To their minds, their culture was almost inconceivably old and well established. They would have been astonished to know that we see them as having been right at the beginning.

Aug 19, 2026

Page 83 | Bookmark (Blue)



Aug 20, 2026

Page 84 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The tombs at Ur were excavated in the 1920s, and they made for sensational news at the time. They were excavated by a team led by a British archaeologist named Leonard Woolley. He employed many workmen on the site at Ur, who uncovered literally thousands of tombs during their excavations.

Aug 20, 2026

Page 87 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Tombs like this have been discovered at a site called Tall Ahmad al Hattu, but from an earlier period than the tombs at Ur.60 At Tall Ahmad, as at Ur, elite people had been buried in houses for the dead.

Aug 21, 2026

Note:

How many tombs like this do we have yet to find?

Aug 21, 2026

4. A Queen, a Reformer, and Weavers

Page 92 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Lugalanda took the throne in Lagash, around 2400 bce, queen Baranamtara did not immediately take over control of the queen’s estate,

Aug 21, 2026

Page 93 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The E-Mi palace was located in the city of Girsu, which was the capital of the city-state of Lagash at this time.

Aug 21, 2026

Page 95 | Highlight (Yellow)

> An important alliance for Baranamtara was with the queen of the city-state of Adab, which lay just upriver of Lagash; the two states shared a border.

Aug 21, 2026

Note:



Aug 21, 2026

Page 96 | Highlight (Yellow)

> To put this in perspective, Dilmun was about 850 kilometers (530 miles) from Lagash, and Urenki would have traveled most of that way, if not the whole way, by boat. Seaworthy boats had been built long before cities developed, though their captains probably stayed within view of the coast as they traveled. It would have been a difficult journey, but evidently was worth the risk. Copper was needed everywhere for making bronze. The copper was not mined in Dilmun, though. It had come from even farther away, from what is now Oman (ancient Magan), where archaeologists have found evidence for extensive mining and smelting.25 Dilmun

Aug 21, 2026

Note:

Could draw out some Sea trade routes

Aug 21, 2026

Page 104 | Highlight (Yellow)

> to have overthrown his predecessor in a violent way.48 Urukagina (mid-twenty-fourth century bce) wanted life in Lagash to go back to the way it had been in the past, or at least to the way he imagined it had been, in some earlier, less decadent time. This would be a way of life that would restore (as he saw it) an appropriate respect for the state god Ningirsu, who would no doubt approve of his actions. Urukagina claimed, using the third person about himself, that “he (re)established the norms of old; the commands which his king the divine Ningirsu had commanded him.”49 Many people, he believed, had been getting rich at the expense of the state and the temples; those people were to be removed from their positions, and even his own royal court was to become a religious institution. “He put the house of the ruler (and) the fields of the ruler in (the hands of) the divine Ningirsu his king.”50

Aug 21, 2026

Note:

LOL MAGA

Aug 21, 2026

5. Royal Couples, Divine Couples, and Envoys

Page 112 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The cuneiform tablets found at the site of Ebla didn’t give up their stories easily.1 In 1974, when Italian excavators first discovered the main archive room in the ancient palace,2 the sight of the clay tablets must have been almost overwhelming. As the archaeologists carefully removed the dirt, thousands of cuneiform tablets appeared, piled on the ground, some still in exactly the order in which they had been placed 4,300 years ago, before the palace burned down

Aug 22, 2026

Note:

How was this site found? Potential for more like it?

Aug 22, 2026

Page 114 | Highlight (Yellow)

> King Ishar-damu of Ebla around 2300 bce, the kingdom was flourishing. Ishar-damu ruled from a sprawling and finely built palace in the capital city, a little more than 54 kilometers (33 miles) south of the already important city of Halab (now Aleppo).8 The palace, which archaeologists uncovered, was spread out over 2,400 square meters (almost 26,000 square feet)9 on an acropolis overlooking the city. The city wall would have been visible in the distance, surrounding the 60 hectares (148 acres) of densely packed buildings that made up Ebla.

Aug 22, 2026

Page 115 | Highlight (Yellow)

> During Ishar-damu's reign, Ebla was one of the major kingdoms of his era; it included at least twenty cities that recognized him as their king, it was home to more than 700 villages that were mentioned in the archives, 10 and it stretched at least 200 kilometers (125 miles) from east to west across northwest Syria. The kingdom of Ebla bordered other powerful kingdoms of the day, Nagar to the east in the Habur River region, and Mari to the southeast along the Euphrates.

Aug 22, 2026

Page 126 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The former kings were gods now, deified after death. The names of these earlier kings of Ebla, sadly, mean nothing to us. We have just a list of them, carefully recorded, passed down by scribes over generations, and found in the excavation of the palace.62 There are twenty-six names on the list, but documents only survive from the reigns of the last four to rule before the destruction of the kingdom—Kun-damu, Igrish-Halab, Irkab-damu, and Ishar-damu—and the vast majority of the tablets that were found in the excavations at Ebla date to just the last two of those.63 Those other kings on the list—they're just names without stories. Some of them would no doubt have been as familiar to the people of Ebla as George Washington or Abraham Lincoln

> are to Americans today.

Aug 23, 2026

Page 134 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Two men, Enar-Lim and Ruzi-malik, made some of the longest journeys from Ebla, traveling all the way to a distant place called Dugurasu.

Aug 24, 2026

Page 136 | Highlight (Yellow)

> One has the sense that the journey back and forth between Ebla and Egypt would have been a familiar one to these men who were traveling together. The first leg of the journey from Ebla took them to the Mediterranean coast at Kakmium. From there, they traveled south, either on foot or by boat, with a stop at the coastal city of Dulu, which was almost certainly an ancient name for Byblos. Archaeology shows that Byblos already had a long history of trade with both Egypt and Syria, and the tablets show that Dulu was one of Ebla's most reliable trading partners, providing many of the same goods that came from Dugurasu. The expedition then continued on from Dulu to Egypt—Dugurasu. They would have traveled about 1,370 kilometers (850 miles) to get there, a journey that would have taken them about two months. With a stay when they got there and the return journey to follow, Enar-Lim and Ruzi-malik were leaving Syria for at least six months. One can't help wondering what the merchants thought of the lands they visited, and all the varying landscapes and cities they encountered along the way. The roads in the kingdom of Ebla and beyond it were well traveled. The people of Ebla knew that a wide world extended beyond their immediate domain, and the mechanisms of diplomacy were well established. Formal gift exchange with distant kings may, in fact, have been more reliable than trade in providing luxury goods for the court.

Aug 25, 2026

Note: map this

Aug 26, 2026

6. A Conqueror and a Priestess

Page 145 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Sargon (c. 2316–2277 bce) is the earliest Big Name in Mesopotamian history. Few people today have heard of Ur-Nanshe, Enmetena, or Ishar-damu, let alone Baranamtara or Tabur-damu. But Sargon is familiar. He is even sometimes known as "Sargon the Great"—the world's first empire builder, the first man to unite Mesopotamia from the Persian Gulf to the Mediterranean.

Aug 26, 2026

Page 146 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Sargon's name and achievements were therefore familiar to people in the region for about 2,000 years, and we hear about him a lot from their later writings. Curiously, though, if the only clues we had were documents and objects that were created in Sargon's own time, he might seem inconsequential—just one of hundreds of kings whose reigns came and went without leaving much trace.

Aug 26, 2026

Note:



Aug 26, 2026

Page 147 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Before Sargon began his imperialistic campaigns, Lugalzagesi, king of Umma (c. 2320 bce), was busily uniting (and laying waste to) much of southern Mesopotamia. The city-state of Umma was, as we have seen, the perpetual nemesis of the city-state of Lagash. They had battled for so long over their shared border that inhabitants of both city-states must have viewed the feud as some kind of fact of life. Soldiers from each state must have assumed that they would forever be sent out by their king with spears, bows, and arrows to fight for their god—Ningirsu (for Lagash) or Shara (for Umma)—to reclaim control of the lands of the Gu'edena. But King Lugalzagesi brought an end to the feud, conquering both Umma's rival, Lagash, and the ancient city of Uruk, to which he then moved his capital. By Lugalzagesi's time, approximately 1,200 years had passed since Uruk had emerged as the first great city of Mesopotamia.

Aug 27, 2026

Page 151 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Unfortunately, there is no way to know if any of this was true because Agade has not yet been found. Archaeologists do know where to look, though—Sargon's new capital probably was built somewhere near the confluence of the Tigris and Adhaim Rivers, north of what is now Baghdad.

Aug 29, 2026

Note:

How can this not be found?

Aug 29, 2026

Page 151 | Highlight (Yellow)

> A giant fragment of an over-lifesize statue of a man made of basalt was found there at a site called Qadasiyah—it would have been a statue appropriate for a capital city (see Fig. 6.2). When complete, the figure stood about 2.75 meters (9 feet) tall, bigger than anything else known from this era.38 Was this Sargon? It might have been. All that is left are his bare feet,

Aug 29, 2026

Note:

So we ~may~ have the feet of Sargon @ what may be Agave

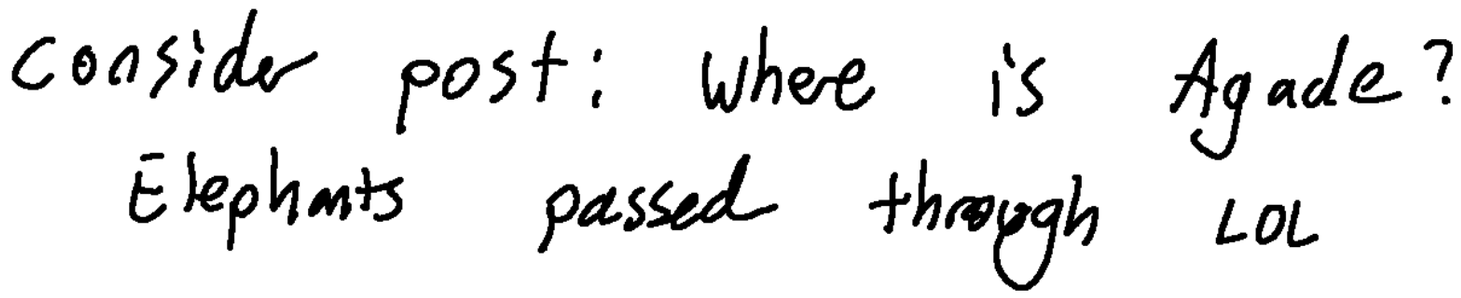
Aug 29, 2026

Page 153 | Highlight (Yellow)

> But Sargon was not content with the traditional trading mechanisms; he initiated a new era of trade by inviting foreign traders and their boats directly to his capital. He boasted in one inscription that boats from Magan, Dilmun, and Meluhha docked at the harbor in Agade.

Aug 29, 2026

Note:



Aug 29, 2026

Page 154 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Sargon decided to name the years; at the end of each year, he chose one of his recent great achievements to be the name of the year that was beginning. Scribes were supposed to use this year-name whenever a date was needed on a document. It was Sargon’s cunning way of reminding his people of his power, and it created a precedent. Mesopotamian kings regularly used year-names as a form of propaganda for more than 700 years after his reign and, in a few states, kings even continued to name their years for at least three more centuries after that.

Aug 29, 2026

Page 154 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Remember that his throne name was already propagandistic, so anyone mentioning the name of a year couldn’t help repeating two ideas that Sargon wanted to reinforce—his legitimacy and his military might. Hence, a farmer might say, “I first grew barley in this field during the year when ‘ The king is legitimate’ destroyed Elam.”

Aug 29, 2026

Page 165 | Highlight (Yellow)

> the most obvious reason for the collapse was that a people called the Gutians invaded Akkad from the Zagros

mountains to the east.

Aug 31, 2026

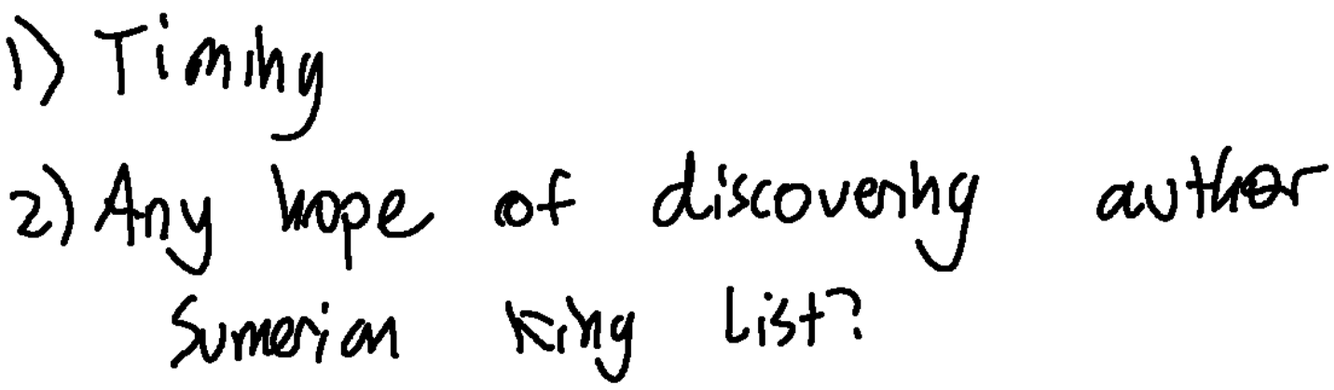
7. Brickmakers, Litigants, and Slaves

Page 167 | Highlight (Yellow)

After the Gutians had conquered Agade and helped bring an end to the Akkadian Empire, no one could claim to be king of the whole land. Even the author of the Sumerian King List, who normally valiantly maintained the fiction of a united Mesopotamia, despaired of making any sense of this era. “Who was king? Who was not king?” he wrote.1 This period was mystifying to the ancient writer and remains so to us.

Sep 1, 2026

Note:



Sep 1, 2026

Page 175 | Highlight (Yellow)

One day, as one of these bricks was drying in the sun, a dog walked across it, leaving clear paw prints in the clay (see Fig. 7.4). Was this a feral dog wandering through the brickmaking yard? No one knows. Dogs had been domesticated in the Near East thousands of years earlier, perhaps as early as 13,000 bce,23 and they would have been a familiar sight in the city.

Sep 3, 2026

Note: bricks for ziggarut at ur

Sep 3, 2026

Page 176 | Highlight (Yellow)

A scholar has calculated that the first level alone of the ziggurat at Ur would have required the manufacture

> of a staggering 7,595,100 baked and sun-dried bricks.25 Our brickmaker would have spent months, perhaps years, doing nothing during his days but mixing clay, molding bricks for this building, and stacking them on their sides to harden.

Sep 3, 2026

Page 179 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Ur-Namma's laws predate Hammurabi's by more than 300 years. Ur-Namma promulgated his laws at the height of his reign, after he had, as he noted in an inscription, "liberated Akshak, Mirad, Girkal, Kazallu, whatever (territories) were under the subjugation of Anshan."38 This was one of his few references to military action. The cities listed were to the north of Ur, in the region of Akkad, whereas Anshan was about 800 kilometers (about 500 miles) to the south and east of Ur, near modern Shiraz in Iran.

Sep 4, 2026

Page 191 | Highlight (Yellow)

> King Ur-Namma's death came suddenly. According to a line in a literary account that may have been commissioned by his widow Watartum, he might have died in battle, but he might also have died naturally.

Sep 5, 2026

Note:



Sep 5, 2026

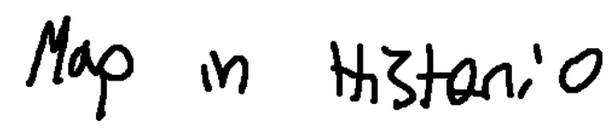
Page 193 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The whole project of administering this system depended on an army of scribes keeping records of every sheep, goat, ox, and bushel of grain that came into and went out of the royal warehouses. Much of the processing of goods took place at a specially constructed redistribution center that Shulgi founded near Nippur. It was called Puzrish-Dagan and was the origin of many of the Ur III records. Shulgi's administrative reforms affect us now, as we look at the sweep of ancient Near Eastern history, because the scribes who ran this system created a veritable flood of cuneiform records (see Fig. 7.6). About 100,000 tablets written in the

> Ur III period have been found so far, and hundreds of thousands more must remain in the ground. It's estimated that about 500,000 cuneiform documents are housed in museums and private collections around the world from all eras of ancient history,112 so about a fifth of them were written during the Third Dynasty of Ur, most of those from Shulgi's reign and those of his successors. They represent just a few decades out of the more than 3,000 years that cuneiform was in use.

Sep 5, 2026

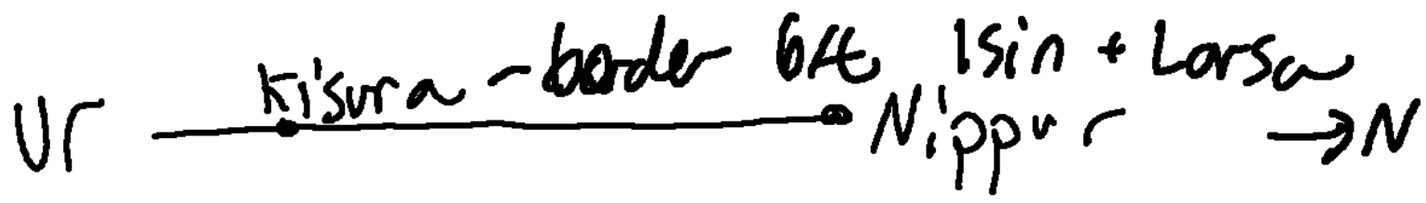
Note:



Sep 5, 2026

8. Sparring Kings and Their Military Commanders

Page 199 | Note



Sep 5, 2026

Page 202 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Ishbi-Erra and the kings who were his descendants are known as the First Dynasty of Isin; they dominated much of Sumer during the 1900s bce. They did their best to make it seem as though the Ur dynasty had not ended. In fact, they continued to call themselves "Kings of Ur" for seventy years.

Sep 5, 2026

Page 203 | **Note**

After Ur: Isin vs Larsa (2000 BC)

Sep 5, 2026

Page 204 | **Highlight (Yellow)**

> And so, in the early 1920s bce, we see kings of Isin being replaced by King Gungunum of Larsa, who took over Kisurra and who imposed his year-names. But, late in the decade, by 1921 bce, the city was back in the kingdom of Isin, with that king's year-names replacing those of the king of Larsa. For a brief time Kisurra claimed independence—four kings of a local dynasty controlled the land (and the year-names),15 but then the king of Larsa was back again in 1910 bce. Twelve more years passed and the city was again in Isin's kingdom. Nine more years and it was in Larsa again. And so it went, on and on for decades, in dizzying succession, until 1802 bce.

Sep 5, 2026

Page 211 | **Highlight (Yellow)**

> Quite a lot more is known about Sumu-El, beyond his letters from the battlefield. He had come to power in 1894 bce, as the seventh king of Larsa. It had been thirty-two years since his predecessor King Gungunum had taken control of Ur and ended the era in which Isin could claim to be home to the "kings of Ur." Larsa, rather than Isin, now saw itself as Ur's rightful heir.

Sep 5, 2026

Page 212 | **Highlight (Yellow)**

> and to undermine the power of Isin. As we have seen, Sumu-El was proud of his military victories and keen to let everyone know about them in his year-names and inscriptions. Curiously, though, none of the details from his letters were mentioned in his year-names for the period

Sep 5, 2026

Note:

On this to do board, we should list all known year-names

Sep 5, 2026

Page 213 | Highlight (Yellow)

> This man had a confusingly similar name to that of his contemporary in Larsa: he was Sumu-la-El (1880–1845 bce). He founded an Amorite dynasty, one that lasted for almost 300 years and put Babylon firmly on the map as a center of power and influence. (Its most famous king, Hammurabi, ruled a century after Sumu-la-El.)

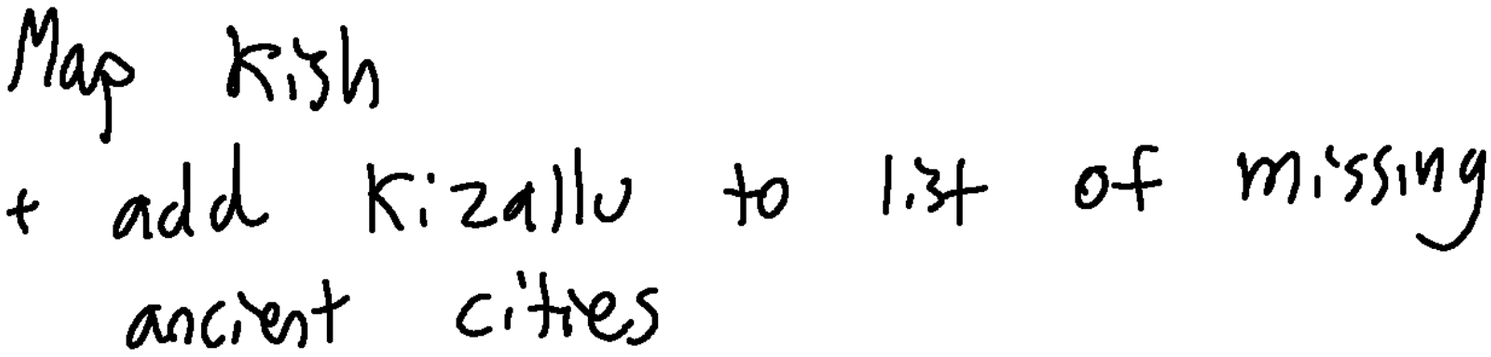
Sep 5, 2026

Page 214 | Highlight (Yellow)

> By his nineteenth year, Sumu-la-El of Babylon had conquered the nearby city of Kish, followed the next year by Kizallu, which was probably to the south (its location hasn’t been found).

Sep 5, 2026

Note:



Sep 5, 2026

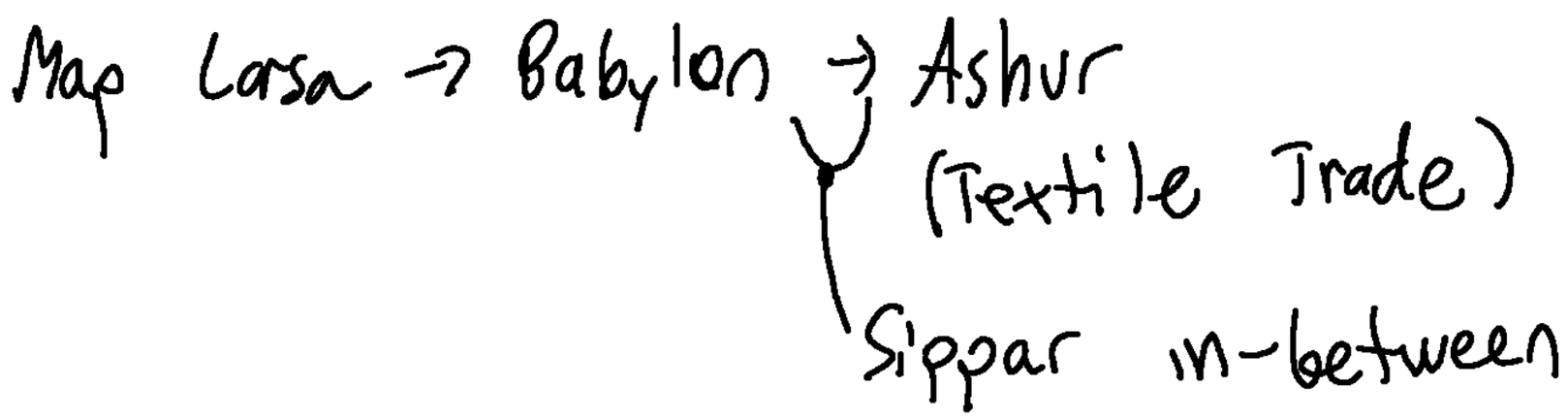
9. Merchants and Families

Page 218 | Highlight (Yellow)

> A group of travelers following the itinerary would have traveled north from Larsa, hugging the route of the Euphrates (see Map 2). They passed the familiar repeating sights of palm trees, long rectangular fields flanked by canals, and villages of mudbrick houses. The travelers arrived in Babylon after being on the road for seven days.

Sep 5, 2026

Note:



Sep 5, 2026

Page 219 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The next stretch of the itinerary left the banks of the Euphrates behind and took the soldiers (and our trading caravan carrying southern textiles) north along the route of a wide canal that flowed from the Tigris to the Euphrates, and then north again along the Tigris River toward the city of Ashur.

Sep 5, 2026

Page 220 | Highlight (Yellow)

> When Ashur was founded, around 2500 bce, its early inhabitants no doubt realized that the triangular site would be relatively easy to defend. It needed just one stretch of city wall, because two branches of the Tigris River came together here and had cut high escarpments out of the rock. The city towered 40 meters (about 130 feet) above the river, with the rivers providing a natural moat and steep cliffs on two of its three sides. By this time, the early second millennium bce, Ashur extended over about 40 hectares (about 100 acres) and had a population of just 5,000–8,000 people. A thousand years later, it would become a great city, the religious heart of the immense Neo-Assyrian Empire,

Sep 5, 2026

Note:



Sep 5, 2026

Page 221 | Highlight (Yellow)

> At the highest point of the city, overlooking the river, stood the imposing temple to the god Ashur. It would have been inconceivable to the Assyrians to build a temple to Ashur in any location other than this—this was where Ashur was physically present. The temple was large, measuring 108 meters (354 feet) by 54 meters (177 feet), with a central courtyard, and although it was frequently rebuilt and restored, its physical plan remained almost unchanged until the seventh century

Sep 5, 2026

Note:

Do remains of Ashur Temple Still exist?

Sep 5, 2026

Page 222 | Highlight (Yellow)

> For 200 years, from around 1970 to 1770 bce, Ashur's heart and soul, its economy, its very raison d'être, lay in its merchants and their far-flung trading activities. It's no wonder, perhaps, that the merchants commanded so much power, and that the Assyrian kings were relatively weak.

Sep 5, 2026

Page 222 | Highlight (Yellow)

> A master list of 145 of the limmum names, inscribed on a cuneiform tablet, was found in 2001, and other lists that have been found can be compiled to provide a sequence of the names of limmum years from 1972 to 1718 bce.

Sep 5, 2026

Note:

limmum = Assyrian chief official chosen from assembly by lot

Sep 5, 2026

Page 223 | Highlight (Yellow)

> as many as 22,460 documents written by merchants from Ashur have been excavated hundreds of miles from the city, at a place called Kanesh, now called Kültepe, all the way off in central Anatolia not far from the modern Turkish city of Kayseri.11 The city of Kanesh, it turns out, was the focus of the trading activities of the merchants of Ashur, the place where the merchants (who ran the City Assembly and served as limmums) created their wealth, and a place where many men from Ashur lived and worked. Excavations there have shown that Kanesh was inhabited by local Anatolians, for the most part, while the Assyrians lived in a community, often referred to as a colony, on the outskirts of the town.

Sep 6, 2026

Note:

Historio: Map it

Sep 6, 2026

Page 233 | Note

Ashur ——— Kanesh

⟶ cloth, silver, donkey

⟵ Tin

Sep 7, 2026

Page 234 | Highlight (Yellow)

> As many as 300 donkeys could be involved in a single caravan, with as many men accompanying them.

Sep 7, 2026

Note:

Such a sight!,
Ashur → Kanesh
Donkeys belong to different companies like modern train cars

Sep 7, 2026

Page 235 | Highlight (Yellow)

> There, the king of Kanesh got to choose what he would take as his taxes on each load (he took a 10 percent tax—one out of every ten textiles) and he could also purchase additional goods from the merchants at the going rate if he chose to.

Sep 7, 2026

10. Princesses and Musicians

Page 238 | Highlight (Yellow)

> According to the text, someone moving on north from Ashur on the ancient road arrived, a day later, at a city called Ekallatum.1 Unfortunately, the location of Ekallatum remains unknown and the site has never been excavated, but it was an important place. Although the itinerary was probably written in the mid-eighteenth century bce,2 the same roads were in use before then, so let us say that a visitor was making the journey in the late nineteenth century bce, when the trade between Ashur and Anatolia was winding down. If so, he might have arrived in Ekallatum at a moment of crisis. King Shamshi-Adad I of Upper Mesopotamia: An Empire Builder Ekallatum had previously been subject to its neighboring kingdom, Ashur, but it had recently been attacked and conquered by forces led by a man named Shamshi-Adad (1807–1776 bce).

Sep 7, 2026

Note:

Ashur → Ekallatum
(never Found)

Sep 7, 2026

Page 240 | Highlight (Yellow)

> This meant that politics, alliances, and rivalries in the north were a little different from those of the south. Although northern kingdoms had capital cities, just as in the south, and their kings were supported by vassals, and their provinces were overseen by governors, a good percentage of the population was nomadic. The royal administrations needed the nomads for military service and to help with harvests and construction projects, so their seasonal arrival in the cities was eagerly anticipated by the kings and their officials.

Sep 7, 2026

Page 241 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Habur triangle, had suffered a loss of population toward the end of the Akkadian Empire around 2200

Sep 7, 2026

Note:

Map Habur Triangle on road N of Shakur

Sep 7, 2026

Page 242 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Even as construction began at Shubat-Enlil, Shamshi-Adad was still expanding his empire to the southwest, pursuing the king of Mari and his army into the heartland of their kingdom, so that eventually Shamshi-Adad's empire extended over all the lands that had previously been ruled by the kings of both Ashur and Mari.

Sep 7, 2026

Note:

Map Shubat-Enlil

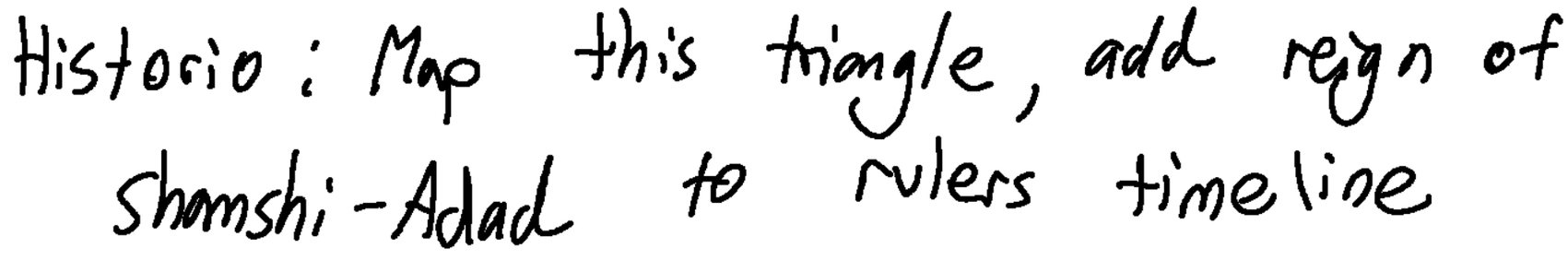
Sep 7, 2026

Page 242 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Shamshi-Adad decided on an innovative way of ruling such a big, unwieldy domain. Rather than trying to control everything himself, he created a triumvirate of kings, with his sons Yasmah-Addu and Ishme-Dagan ruling alongside him. Each man had his own capital: Shamshi-Adad at the city of Shubat-Enlil in the north, Ishme-Dagan at the original capital of Ekallatum in the east, and Yasmah-Addu at the newly conquered Mari, to the south of Shubat-Enlil. But the three men were not equals. The sons answered to their father, and this caused tensions, especially between Shamshi-Adad and his younger son, Yasmah-Addu. We know about this because Yasmah-Addu's capital city and palace at Mari have been extensively excavated since 1933, by successive teams of French archaeologists, and because Mari (like Girsu, Ebla, and Kanesh) has proved to be one of the greatest Near Eastern sites in terms of its preserved archives: more than 20,000 cuneiform tablets have been found there. Some of them are the original letters sent by Shamshi-Adad to Yasmah-Addu, and many of them reveal his micromanagement of his son's realm.15

Sep 7, 2026

Note:



Sep 7, 2026

Page 245 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Ishar-damu and Tabur-damu. In Yasmah-Addu's time, the Mari palace was divided into several extensive suites of rooms, used for a variety of purposes and laid out around two huge courtyards (marked as 3 and 10 in Fig. 10.1). The grand front entrance, on the north side (1), led to a wide reception room (2), from which visitors would have been ushered into the sunny glare of the main courtyard (3), which was about 1,600 square meters (17,000 square feet) in extent, or about the size of four basketball courts.

Sep 7, 2026

Note:

Historic - Add map pin for Palace at Mari

Sep 7, 2026

Page 254 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Rishiya's house in Mari (which was separate from the palace) served as the conservatory for all the many musicians whom he mentored.57 It has never been excavated, but it must have been large, and it must have been loud, full of music and singing. (Perhaps Rishiya's neighbors sometimes wished that the percussionists could rehearse in the temple or the palace rather than next door.) Women must have passed one another as they entered and left through the front door, greeting each other as they carried their instruments in for classes or rehearsals. Beltani and Bazatum were immersed in this community.

Sep 8, 2026

Note:

Do we know where the house is?

Page 262 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Two years later, the palace of Zimri-Lim—that sprawling, glorious complex—burned to the ground and was never rebuilt. It must have burned for hours, perhaps for days. The people of the city experienced the strange horror of witnessing the destruction of a monument that must have seemed eternal and that had for centuries represented continuity, even when dynasties had changed. Fortunately, by the time of the fire, palace residents had long since moved out; the contents of the palace had been sorted through and the finest treasures removed beforehand. Now fire poured out of the rooftops and the doorways. Ceiling beams holding up the second floor burst into flames, and upper floors collapsed. The fire was so hot that it baked hard the bricks in the walls and the clay tablets in the archives, serendipitously preserving them for us, their unimagined readers, far in the future.

Sep 9, 2026

11. A Lawgiver, Land Overseers, and Soldiers

Page 267 | Highlight (Yellow)

> I don’t think there’s a world history survey in existence that fails to mention Hammurabi of Babylon (1792–1750 bce). Even if only two or three pages are devoted to all of Mesopotamian history—all 3,500 years of it—Hammurabi still makes it in there.

Sep 9, 2026

Page 269 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Initially Hammurabi’s Babylonian kingdom existed in the shadow of three much more powerful states: Upper Mesopotamia to the north, Larsa to the south, and Elam to the east. When Hammurabi ascended to the throne in 1792 bce at the death of his father, he was a young man. The now middle-aged Shamshi-Adad was still ruling the wide reaches of Upper Mesopotamia. Larsa, which continued to dominate Sumer, as it had for a century ever since the time of Sumu-El, was now ruled by king Rim-Sin (1822–1763 bce). He, like Shamshi-Adad, was at least a generation older than Hammurabi; he had already been in power for thirty years and, during that time, had dramatically increased the size of his kingdom. He had even finally conquered Larsa’s longtime rival, Isin.3 Unlike almost all the earlier kings of Larsa, or of anywhere else in the 1790s bce, Rim-Sin considered himself to be a god. The third power, Elam, is less well known to us, but was apparently the most powerful of them all. Siruk-tuh (early eighteenth century bce) was its leader when Hammurabi first ruled.4 He and later kings of the Elamite dynasty were referred to as “great king” and “father” by kings in Syria

Sep 9, 2026

Page 270 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Year: Hammurabi the king, trusting [the gods] An and Enlil, who marches in front of his army, and with the supreme power which the great gods have given to him, destroyed the troops of Emutbal, and subjugated its king Rim-Sin, and brought Sumer and Akkad to dwell under his authority.

Sep 10, 2026

Page 275 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The landscape around Larsa might have looked bucolic and uncomplicated—field beyond rectangular field

> stretching along the river to the horizon, interwoven with gently trickling irrigation canals—but each field had an individual story. It could be privately owned and farmed by its owner and his or her family, or owned by a private individual but farmed by a tenant or by hired laborers. It could be owned by the state and farmed by an entrepreneur, or owned by the state and awarded to a worker as an ilkum. It could be owned by a temple and farmed by temple employees, tenants, or hired laborers, or it could be owned by a temple and in the hands of an entrepreneur. Rich families who owned vast private land holdings could also function much like temples in the ways in which they managed their land. Into this byzantine situation came Shamash-hazir, valiantly trying to track down information about who farmed, and who owned, every field in his region and sending regular reports to the king.

Sep 11, 2026

Page 279 | Highlight (Yellow)

> In many of the letters to Shamash-hazir, Hammurabi reminded him to hold on to, or to consult, existing records—there is a lot of mention of “tablets” and “reports.” Shamash-hazir’s physical office hasn’t been excavated, but it must have included rooms full of documents that he could consult if disputes arose. The tablets may have been organized by date, with inscribed clay labels identifying the contents of shelves or boxes to help the administrator find the documents he needed. Such labels have been found at a number of sites.

Sep 11, 2026

Note:

Has a comparable office been found?
How much is left of it?
Could this office still exist somewhere?

Sep 11, 2026

Page 282 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Toward the end of his long life, Hammurabi decided to put out a proclamation that would be posted in public, on big stone stelas. One of them has survived intact and is now in the Louvre Museum in Paris. It's the one I described at the start of this chapter: seven feet tall, a polished block of basalt, with a relief sculpture of Hammurabi at the top, receiving his right to rule from the sun god Shamash (Fig. 11.1).55 We know this stela best for the hundreds of laws that are preserved on it—this is the so-called "Code of Hammurabi"—

Sep 11, 2026

Page 286 | Highlight (Yellow)

> poorer soldiers. "If there are not sufficient means in his estate to redeem him, he shall be redeemed by his city' s temple."

Sep 12, 2026

Note:



Sep 12, 2026

Page 287 | Highlight (Yellow)

> In a similar spirit, Hammurabi ruled that physicians should charge their patients for treatment on a sliding scale depending on wealth. An awilum was charged 5 shekels to have a broken bone fixed, whereas a commoner had to pay only 3 shekels for exactly the same procedure.

Sep 12, 2026

Page 288 | Highlight (Yellow)

> More than a thousand years after they were first written, a copy of the laws was kept by an Assyrian king named Ashurbanipal in his palace library.

Sep 12, 2026

Note:

Compare laws we revere from 1000 years ago to veneration of Hammarabi's Code

Sep 12, 2026

12. Naditums and Scribal Students

Page 289 | Highlight (Yellow)

> During the Ur III period and earlier, cuneiform tablets were almost always found in institutional buildings, where they had been written and stored by scribes who worked for the relevant palace or temple. The average person in those earlier eras had little contact with, or even need for, the written word—cuneiform was used almost exclusively by the religious and political administrations.2 But, starting in the Isin-Larsa period,

Sep 12, 2026

Note:

Histori: definitely need a timeline of just these periods in the region

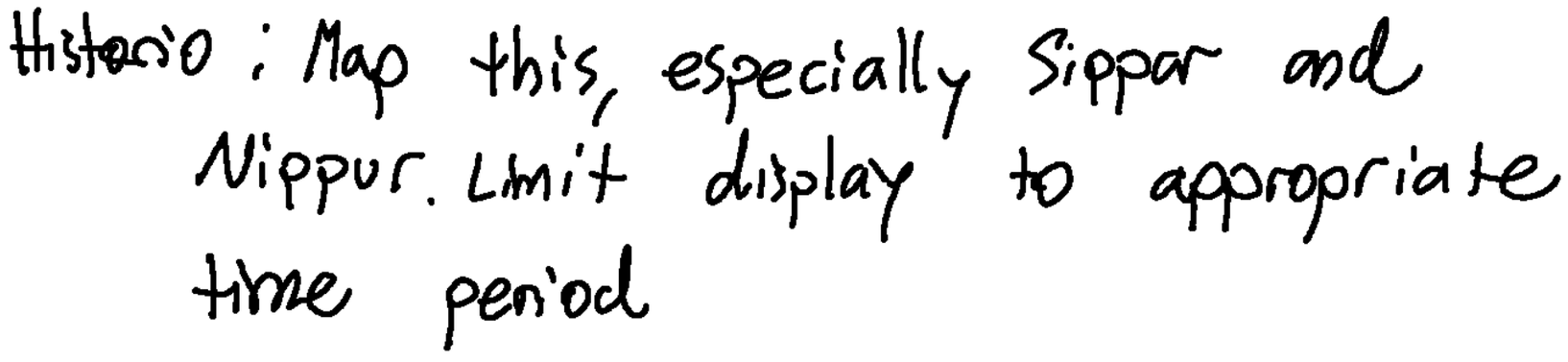
Sep 12, 2026

Page 290 | Highlight (Yellow)

> During the reign of Hammurabi, Sippar played an integral role in the kingdom. It was actually made up of two cities—Sippar-Yahrurum (the main city) and Sippar-Amnanum (the suburb)—6 kilometers (3.7 miles) apart from one another and just 60 kilometers (37 miles) north of Babylon.4 The main city (which I will refer to as just Sippar) was home to the god of wisdom, Shamash, the sun god himself.

Sep 13, 2026

Note:



Sep 13, 2026

Page 298 | Highlight (Yellow)

> As many as 300 women are known to have lived in the gagum at Sippar during the reign of Hammurabi,39 so perhaps quite a few girls participated in the initiation each year. One girl who went through this was named Awat-Aya.40 The gagum kept an account of the expenses involved in her induction,

Sep 14, 2026

Page 303 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Sippar was one of many cities housing naditums during the reign of Hammurabi; another important center for them was in Nippur, home to Enlil, the great god of the whole Mesopotamian region. Nippur was north of Isin and south of Babylon, and by the reign of Hammurabi it had been a major city for hundreds of years. In Nippur, the right of women to become naditums had been held strictly within certain families that had lived within the city for a long period of time.

Sep 15, 2026

Note:

Naditum = community of unwed women who commune w/gods

Sep 15, 2026

Page 309 | Highlight (Yellow)

> By now Elletum and his classmates were sometimes given a different type of tablet to write on. The master scribe wrote out the relevant lines that the student was to learn on the left-hand side of a rectangular tablet. The student dutifully copied the lines on the right-hand side. After his master had seen (and presumably critiqued) the student's work, he didn't recycle the tablet—that would be a waste of the master's beautiful exemplar on the left. Instead the scribe wiped his own work clean with a stone eraser, or just with his fingers (you can often see the scribe's fingerprints when he did this) and tried it again.

Sep 16, 2026

Page 311 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Although mathematics has continued to be practiced in Iraq ever since the time of these early mathematicians, much of the Old Babylonian mathematical knowledge was lost with the collapse of this era, and it turns out that even the later forms of Mesopotamian mathematics probably didn't have a discernable influence on Greek thinkers.93 The Greeks seem to have rediscovered and invented new ways to approach mathematical problems that had been solved more than a thousand years before.

Sep 16, 2026

Page 313 | Highlight (Yellow)

> In the course of his advanced studies, Elletum almost certainly copied and memorized stories pertaining to an ancient hero and king of Uruk known as Gilgamesh. He's another of the big names of ancient Near Eastern history, like Sargon and Hammurabi, but the familiar epic about his search for immortality had not yet been written in Elletum's time. Until the Old Babylonian period, Gilgamesh had been known as Bilgames, and he featured as the hero of a number of Sumerian poems that had been passed down orally over generations. At some point during the Ur III period, scribes began writing these tales down and using them as school exercises. Hundreds of years later, around the thirteenth century bce, these poems and other works about the

> hero eventually inspired an author named Sin-leqi-unnini to write the version of the Epic of Gilgamesh that is well known today, but that was still far off in the future when Elletum was in school.

Sep 17, 2026

Note: could we do a whole timeline just on gilgamesh?

Sep 17, 2026

Page 314 | Highlight (Yellow)

> But one of the works copied by a scribal student was different in many ways—it was relatively new at the time, and more ambitious than the earlier tales. Bilgames's name had been changed to Gilgamesh, and the tale was written in the contemporary Akkadian language (though the text was bilingual, also including a translation into ancient Sumerian).108 A fragment of this new work about Gilgamesh was found by the archaeologists in House F, and it can be combined with other fragments from elsewhere to get a sense of what its author had achieved. It was apparently the first iteration of the Epic of Gilgamesh, perhaps the earliest epic poem ever written, and it dealt with themes of friendship, fame, kingship, and fear of death, in ways that are still compelling today. This early epic contained many of the events repeated by Sin-leqi-unnini in his later version, which the Mesopotamians called "He Who Saw Everything," from its first line.

Sep 18, 2026

13. Barbers, Mercenaries, and Exiles

Page 319 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The warm relationship that Hammurabi seems to have achieved with his subjects, and the loyalty he inspired, did not continue into the reign of his son, Samsu-iluna (1749–1712 bce).

Sep 19, 2026

Page 321 | Highlight (Yellow)

> A garrison town on the Euphrates called Harradum was controlled by Samsu-iluna—

Sep 19, 2026

Page 326 | Highlight (Yellow)

> After Samsu-iluna's death in 1712 bce, his son Abi-eshuh (1711–1684 bce) took the throne in Babylon. He seems to have been obsessed with tackling the crisis in the south and bringing an end to the power of the Sealand.

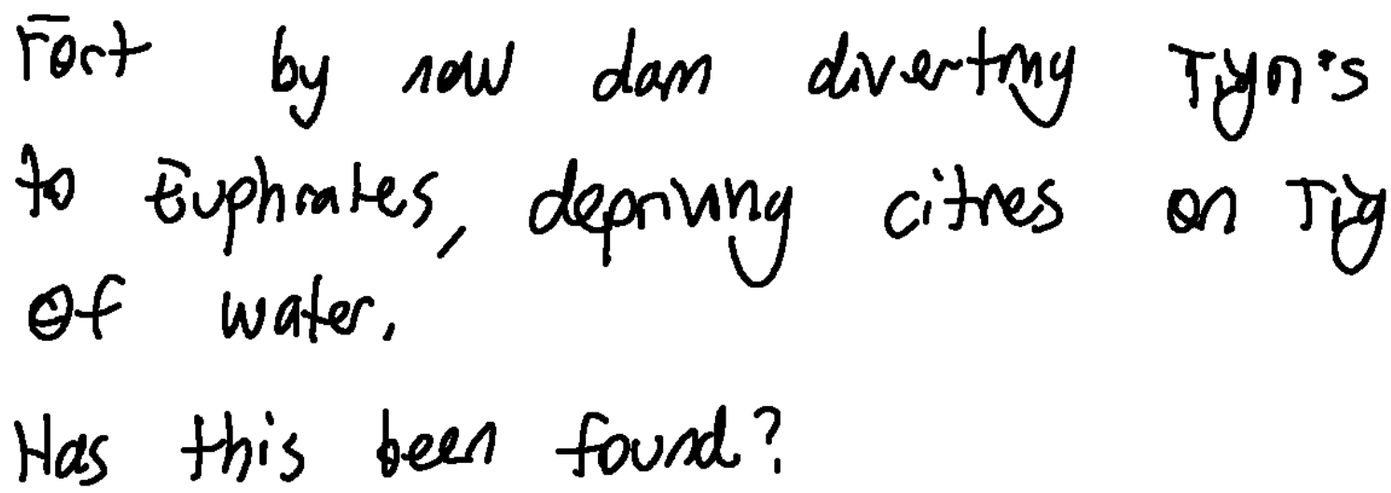
Sep 19, 2026

Page 328 | Highlight (Yellow)

> He named it Fort-Abi-eshuh, or Dur-Abi-eshuh in Akkadian. This fort also was the subject of a year-name: “The year King Abi-eshuh built Dur-Abi-eshuh above the barrage of the Tigris.”35 It actually wasn’t the first fort that he’d named after himself. There was already another one on the Euphrates where Hammurabi’s old canal joined it.36

Sep 19, 2026

Note:



Sep 19, 2026

Page 328 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Throughout the reign of Abi-eshuh, troops traveled easily up and down the Euphrates in boats. They also sailed from the Euphrates to the Tigris and back, along Hammurabi’s canal, which was wide and deep enough for boat traffic.

Sep 19, 2026

Note:

Does canal still exist?,

Sep 19, 2026

Page 330 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Nevertheless, the forts named for Abi-eshuh continued to be occupied and manned for another century, through the reigns of the subsequent kings of Babylon: Ammi-ditana (1683–1647 bce), Ammi-saduqa (1646–1626 bce), and Samsu-ditana (1625–1595 bce).

Sep 19, 2026

Page 330 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The city of Nippur had been largely abandoned after the thirtieth year of Samsu-iluna's reign.50 But its vast and imposing temple, called the Ekur, was still there. It could not be shut down—it was, after all, home to Enlil, the greatest of the Sumerian gods, and had been the holiest place in southern Mesopotamia at least since writing began in the Early Dynastic period, almost a thousand years before.

Sep 19, 2026

Page 334 | Highlight (Yellow)

> the mid-seventeenth century bce, during the same time that Enlil-mansum was engaging in his trading expeditions, and the kings Ammi-saduqa and, later, Samsu-ditana of Babylon were struggling to hold on to the vestiges of the empire that their predecessor Hammurabi had created a century before, a kingdom in Anatolia was changing in ways that had a lasting impact on the whole Near East. The people living on the Anatolian plateau were descendants of the population who had lived there during the time of the Old Assyrian colonies at Kanesh, still speaking the same language, which they called Neshite, but we call Hittite. Hittite was an Indo-European language, the very earliest one to be written down.

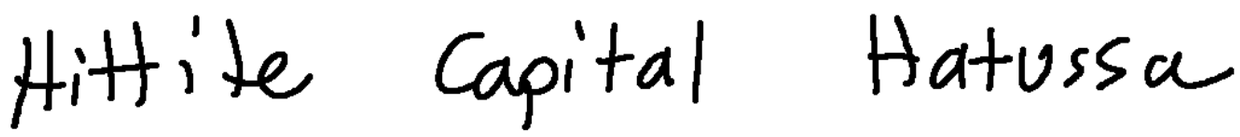
Sep 20, 2026

Page 334 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Around 1750 bce, a new capital city was established high on the Anatolian plateau at a site now called Boğazköy, 200 kilometers (124 miles) east of modern Ankara. A town had existed there since before the time of the Assyrian colonies, though it had been abandoned. But it was an ideal spot for a well-defended capital,

Sep 20, 2026

Note:



Sep 20, 2026

Page 335 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The king who chose Hattusa as his capital may have originally ruled from Kanesh (also called Nesha),72 and he took the name Hattusili, “man of Hattusa,” probably in honor of his new capital. Since several later kings adopted the same name, to us he is Hattusili I (1650–1620 bce).

Sep 20, 2026

Page 336 | Highlight (Yellow)

> King Samsu-ditana proved to be the last king of Babylon in this era. Some enemy force destroyed and looted Babylon in 1595 bce, but we don’t know how this happened or what led up to it. Like a good detective story, tantalizing clues remain, but we can’t be sure what they mean.

Sep 20, 2026

Page 339 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Only two Mesopotamian kingdoms in the sixteenth century bce are known to have kept on producing documents. One was the Sealand in the south,91 and the other was Hana in the north,92 but neither is understood well. Perhaps in the future they will help fill in our understanding of this era. The Hittites, too, continued to produce some documents during this time, though Hatti descended into crisis after its attack on Babylon.

Sep 21, 2026

14. Businessmen, Charioteers, and Translators

Page 345 | Highlight (Yellow)

> forces in Alalakh to master chariot warfare, because the city was located in a spot not unlike that of Kisurra during the earlier Isin-Larsa period (though hundreds of kilometers distant): it was right at the border between two powerful kingdoms, Hatti in Anatolia and a new state called Mittani in Syria.

Sep 21, 2026

Page 349 | Highlight (Yellow)

> This means that there are a great many things we don’t know about Mittani. We don’t know, for example, the exact location of its capital city in the Habur region, or the sequence of its kings, or the lengths of their reigns, or the structure of the government. Even the name of the kingdom itself is uncertain. The name Mittani was spelled in several different ways by its kings, on their cylinder seals and letters,11 and scribes in other lands spelled the same word in two more ways.12 But the land also had a number of completely different names, depending on who was writing about it. To the Egyptians, Mittani was called Naharina; the Hittites referred to it as the Hurri-land (for its Hurrian inhabitants); and the Babylonians (and Mittanians themselves, for that matter) often called it Hanigalbat. The terms all seem to have referred to the same place. Presumably when Mittani’s capital city of Washshukanni is identified and excavated,

Sep 22, 2026

Note:

Where is this likely to be?

Sep 22, 2026

Page 356 | Highlight (Yellow)

> They each had little trouble taking over lesser powers: Egypt had conquered neighboring Canaan to the north and Nubia to the south; Hatti had conquered many lands across Anatolia; Mittani had conquered Assyria and most of Syria.

Sep 23, 2026

Note:

Map these Kingdoms

Sep 23, 2026

Page 369 | Highlight (Yellow)

> His document was published in 1897,2 and it remains the sole witness not just to Abi-hunni's life but to the time of a king named Ishar-Lim of Hana, in eastern Syria. Abi-hunni, King Ishar-Lim, and the fourteen other men named on the same tablet are the only individuals whose names survive, so far, from the entire reign.

Sep 25, 2026

Note:

Single document for entire decades of a civilization. 14 people known

Sep 25, 2026

Page 370 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The scribe also noted that the house could not be reclaimed by someone else, even in cases of an edict releasing borrowers from debt. This presumably meant that it had previously been home to another family who might have tried to get it back. Such a person would have to pay a huge fine of ten minas of silver, and the tablet notes that "his head will be smeared with hot asphalt."4 This sounds horribly painful but, in Hana, it had been the standard penalty for challenging a real estate contract for centuries, and one has the sense that by now it was just a required legal clause, not an actual threat.

Sep 25, 2026

Page 371 | Bookmark (Blue)



Sep 25, 2026

Page 375 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Burna-Buriash II became the father-in-law of King Akhenaten of Egypt (c. 1353–1336 bce), of King Suppiluliuma I of Hatti (c. 1344–1322 bce), and of King Untash-Napirisha of Elam (c. 1340–1300 bce), and he became the son-in-law of King Ashur-uballit I of Assyria (c. 1363–1328 bce). Perhaps not until the time of Britain's Queen Victoria were the children and grandchildren of a monarch so entwined with the royal families of other states.

Sep 26, 2026

Page 383 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Elam, the land immediately to the east of Babylonia, extended from the Tigris River floodplain up into the Zagros Mountains in what is now Iran.63 Although it had been a major power in previous centuries, it was not now a member of the great king brotherhood, at least not from the perspective of the king of Egypt.

Sep 27, 2026

Page 386 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Untash-Napirisha's choice of location for his new city was a site that is now called Chogha Zanbil, just 40 kilometers (25 miles) southeast of Susa. It was a dramatic spot on a high plateau, with views of a wide green river valley. When the city was excavated in the 1950s and early 1960s, by a French archaeological team, it proved to be in remarkable condition.

Sep 27, 2026

Page 390 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Assyrian king Ashur-uballit I (1365–1330 bce).96 Even before the disintegration of the land of Mittani, the Assyrian king (who was at that time still a vassal of Mittani) had been itching for independence and campaigning to join the great king brotherhood. Ashur-uballit had adopted the title "king of Assyria" (he was the first ruler to do so), apparently while King Tushratta of Mittani was still alive, and he had even sent messengers to Egypt with a short, tentative letter and some gifts for the pharaoh Akhenaten.

Sep 28, 2026

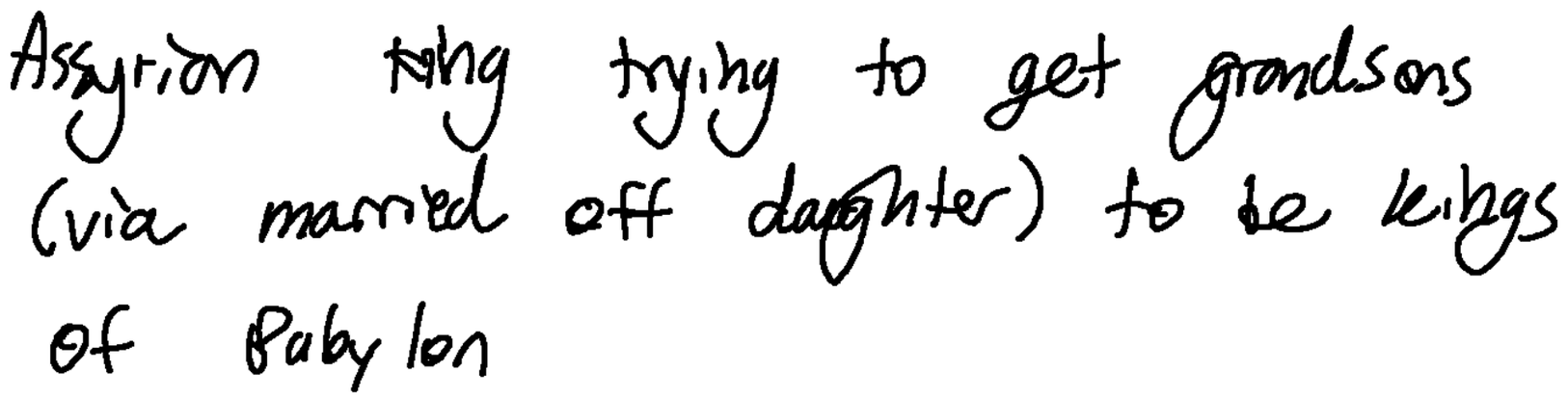
Page 392 | Highlight (Yellow)

> These events are described by a few terse phrases in the chronicle, but it's clear that within one year, 1333

> bce, the Babylonians were ruled by three successive, and mutually antagonistic, kings. It must have been a nerve-wracking time, very different from the calm years of Burna-Buriash II's reign.

Sep 28, 2026

Note:



Sep 28, 2026

16. Negotiators, Sea Traders, and Famine Sufferers

Page 393 | Highlight (Yellow)

> In Egypt, pharaoh Ramses II (1279–1213 bce) dominated almost the whole thirteenth century bce. He was probably born around 1303 bce and lived for a remarkable ninety years; his twelve eldest sons predeceased him. He brought Egypt back to a pinnacle of wealth and power and took credit for more monuments than any king before him.

Sep 28, 2026

Page 394 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The Assyrians conquered what was left of Mittani—already a shadow of its former self—around 1250 bce. They created a new vassal kingdom there, ruled by the son of the king of Assyria and centered on a city called Dur-Katlimmu on the Habur River.

Sep 28, 2026

Page 400 | Highlight (Yellow)

> From the fourteenth to the twelfth centuries bce, Ugarit's diverse, multilingual population produced documents in five scripts (including the Cypro-Minoan script, which was used on the island of Cyprus and is still undeciphered).

Sep 29, 2026

Page 406 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Near a place called Ulu Burun, off the coast of Turkey, underwater archaeologists in the 1980s and 1990s discovered the wreck of a ship, almost 14 meters (45 feet) long, which had been traveling from Cyprus, probably en route to the Aegean, around 1300 bce.59 Its hold was crammed with riches. Lying on the sea floor, still lined up on the ancient wooden boards of the hull, were more than 9,000 kilograms (10 tons) of copper ingots, more than 900 kilograms (one ton) of tin ingots, more than 300 kilograms (700 pounds) of glass ingots, and dozens of jars that had contained oils and other substances, along with many smaller luxury items.60 To judge from their possessions, the crewmembers seem to have been Canaanite (though there's no way to know from which city-state), and two Mycenaean diplomats were on board as well.

Sep 29, 2026

Page 413 | Highlight (Yellow)

> Two-year-old Ba'la-bia and one-year-olds Ba'la-belu and Ishma'-Dagan must have been held by their mother Ku'e as each child in turn placed his or her right foot on a lump of clay and stepped down hard. Baby Ba'la-ummi was too small at this point; she made no footprint in clay. The lumps of clay bearing the footprints were then handed around to the scribe and to the gathered witnesses and treated as though they were documents. The children's names were written on them. One reads, "The foot of Ba'la-belu, son of Zadamma, son of Karbu, the man from Shatappa," and the equivalent inscriptions were added for the other two children on their respective footprints.92 Witnesses who were present for the transaction then rolled their seals on the clay around the footprints.

Oct 1, 2026

Note:

Children sold into slavery in Emar,
footprints in clay found

Oct 1, 2026

Page 415 | Highlight (Yellow)

> their very existence, has been debated extensively. The "Sea Peoples" is the modern name for a group of invaders and settlers who showed up in Egypt during the reign of Ramses III (1186–1155 bce); they arrived in

> the mid-twelfth century bce.

Oct 1, 2026

17. Empire Builders, Sculptors, and Deportees

Page 421 | Highlight (Yellow)

> The year 1200 bce is traditionally seen as the start of the Iron Age in the Near East, the third phase of the Stone-Bronze-Iron Age pattern to ancient history invented by scholars in the nineteenth century. But the moment of the division between the Bronze and Iron Ages is fairly arbitrary. The earliest known evidence for iron smelting has been found in Anatolia at a site that was occupied long before, during the Assyrian Colonies period, but it seems to have had little impact and the technology didn't spread at that time.1 By about 1000 bce, there's more evidence for iron smelting in Anatolia and in the Levant, but, even then, it didn't immediately change much of anything,

Oct 2, 2026
